

Oscar Larnce



Clifton's Pat Olsen has made good things happen for many of us. He is loved and respected by all of baseball although he never realized a goal of being a big league pitcher.

He has attended 199 World Series games, most All-Star games and witnessed the induction of many friends into baseball's hall of fame at Cooperstown. Many have been his guests at the World Series.

Tuesday was the biggest day of Pat Olsen's life.

Old Texas Aggies from everywhere joined this generation's crowd to dedicate a new \$2 million baseball stadium in his honor. Four generations of his family shared the tribute to Pat and his wife Elsie — Edwin (Pat Jr.) and Martha Olsen, grandson Steve and Peggy Olsen and great-granddaughter Stefany. So did a busload of hometown folks headed by Mayor Charles Isenhower. Among them was Dr. S. L. Witcher, Baylor Athletic Hall of Famer.

ALSO THERE were three other members of the 1923 Aggie baseball team, on which Pat was star pitcher — Capt. Buggs Morris, Jack Forgason and Stanley Chapman. Roger Simpson was unable to attend because of illness in the family. Hall of Fame umpire Jocko Conlan temporarily came out of retirement to work three innings of the Aggie-Southern California game. The Trojans spoiled a perfect day by beating Tom Chandler's Aggies on a two-run homer and big league prospect Bill Bordley's four-hit pitching. The southpaw sophomore is 4-0 for the season and 18-0 for his career.

Trojan coach Rod Dedeaux sprang a surprise in the dedication ceremonies by presenting Olsen a USC T-shirt in Trojan colors. He also presented school officials a serving tray engraved with the USC seal. Dedeaux is college baseball's biggest winner and has sent most players to the big leagues. Fred Lynn, Boston Red Sox rookie of the year and MVP in 1975, is one of his boys. His gifts delighted the partisan Aggie crowd.

Associate Director of Athletics Marvin Tate presided over dedication ceremonies. Speakers were President Jarvis E. Miller, Athletic Director and football coach Emory Bellard, and Chandler, who said he was always trying to get "a little better dirt to play on but didn't expect a stadium with it."

Clyde H. Wells, chairman of the Texas A&M board of regents, presented the field and name to Dr. Miller, who unveiled a bronze plaque to place on the stadium. Olsen said in his acceptance speech that baseball training and self-discipline instilled by Texas A&M coaches played important roles in his dedication to sport and in the direction of life's endeavors. He was presented a miniature of the

stadium plaque and an engraved portrait.

C.E. (PAT) OLSEN stadium gives his old school one of the finest college baseball facilities in the nation. It has a natural grass surface and is aligned in a north-south direction with the pitcher facing south. It is located across the road from Kyle Field. Dimensions are 330 feet down each foul line, 370 feet to the power alleys in right and left-center fields and 400 feet to center. There is a 15-foot warning track next to the outfield fence and from first base to third base in front of the grandstand.

The partially covered two-deck grandstand seats approximately 5,000. There were 4,200 fans present for the dedication. Seating for 2,600 in the central section are riser-mounted, aluminum chairs with armrests. Seating for 1,200 on each side is bench-type aluminum with backrests.

THE ENCLOSED PRESSBOX has two broadcast booths for radio, a scorer's booth with public address system and controls for the electronic scoreboard and work space for 12 writers. There are dressing rooms for teams and umpires, Chandler's office, a training room, equipment room and groundskeeper's room under the grandstand.

The stadium was built for future growth with room for extension of the stadium on each side. There is an asphalt parking area for 800 cars and special access ramps for the handicapped.

A&M is defending Southwest Conference champion and it would be a complete tribute to Olsen if the Aggies should win again. The race is wide open with Baylor, Arkansas, Houston and Texas Tech battling perennial winners A&M and Texas.

Old athletes have a never-ending store of delightful stories and will talk all night if given a chance. We're sorry we missed Conlan's session Monday night. He and old New York Giant Hall of Famer Fred Lindstrom were still going at the buffet luncheon which almost filled a large room in the student center. Talk got around to El Paso sports legend Andy Cohen. Andy was one of the Giants' first Jewish ballplayers. Waco Cubs' manager Del Pratt sold him to John McGraw for \$20,000.

In 1928, McGraw traded Rogers Hornsby to the Boston Braves. Cohen replaced Hornsby at second base and was on a hitting spree while Rogers was starting slow. New York paper began printing batting average comparisons of the two every day.

"Rogers said they shouldn't do it," said Lindstrom. "It would hurt the kid." That probably had nothing to do with it but Hornsby batted .387 with 21 home runs. Cohen had a good year with .274.